Operations Manager

You hold everything a coordinator holds, plus the reversals, the rate cards and the reference data. This chapter covers the difference.

> Read `00-orientation.md` and then `01-coordinator.md` — everything in the coordinator's chapter is yours too, and it is not repeated here.

What is yours alone

	WHY IT SITS WITH YOU AND NOT BELOW YOU
Cancel, complete and close shipments	A coordinator moves work forward. Reversing it is an escalation, and it should cost a conversation.
Close enquiries won or lost	Win rate is a number that gets managed if the people measured on it can set it.
Accept and reject quotations	The commercial decision, not the administrative one.
Write rate cards	The pricing of every future quotation comes from here.
Add agents, hauliers and carriers	Your partner network is a register, not a free-text field.
Add ports, places and reference data	Deliberately operational, not administrative — see below.
Read reports	The dashboards and every export.

You cannot touch invoices. Approving, issuing, voiding or crediting an invoice is Finance's alone, and an operations manager who could issue invoices is the segregation-of-duties failure an auditor asks about first. This is not an oversight and it is not configurable in the shipped role matrix.

Reading the dashboard properly

The dashboard is built to be read in one pass, top to bottom, and the order is the argument.

The line at the top tells you how many things need you today. When it says nothing does, believe it.

The four numbers that mean something is wrong now

	WHAT IT IS ACTUALLY TELLING YOU
SLA breached	Enquiries you promised to answer and have not. Not a backlog — a broken promise, and it is countable.
Due today	The ones about to join them. This is where a morning is well spent.

	WHAT IT IS ACTUALLY TELLING YOU
Demurrage accruing	Containers past their free days. This number is money leaving, per day, right now.
Exceptions	Everything wrong on live shipments, oldest first.

Oldest first is the whole point. The newest exception has somebody looking at it. The one at the top of that list has been open longest, which usually means it belongs to nobody. Work down from the top, not up from the bottom.

The four numbers that tell you how the business is running

	HOW TO READ IT
Win rate	Quotes won against quotes sent this month. Falling win rate with stable volume is a pricing problem; falling volume with stable win rate is a demand problem. They need different responses.
Average margin	What you keep on a typical quotation before overheads. Watch it against win rate — a rising win rate and a falling margin means somebody is buying work.
Median response	Enquiry to quotation. The number your customers actually experience. Averages hide the bad days; this is the median for that reason.
Enquiries received	Fourteen days, with the previous week for comparison.

The rest

Shipments by stage and by mode — what is moving and how. **Busiest lanes** — by shipment count, which is where rate-card attention pays for itself. **Where the cargo is** — every live shipment drawn as a line; thicker means more of them.

Arriving this week is the one to check on a Sunday morning. Everything on it needs documents ready and clearance arranged before it lands, and the cost of finding out late is demurrage.

Rate cards

Network → Rate cards. This screen is the most valuable one you own, and the subtitle states the case: *a lane with no live buying rate is a lane you are quoting blind.*

The four numbers at the top

	WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT
Live rate cards	Valid today.
Lanes with a buying rate	Distinct lanes you can price from a contract rather than from memory.
Lanes priced blind	**Start here.** You are shipping on these with no buying rate on file. Each one is a margin you are guessing.
Expiring within 30 days	Renew before the next quotation needs them, not after a customer notices.

Buy and sell

Cards come in two directions. A **buy** card is what an agent or carrier charges you and belongs to that partner. A **sell** card is what you publish, either to everyone or to a named customer.

What each lane earns pairs them by lane and shows the thinnest margins first. Those are the lanes to renegotiate — and it is a better list than the one you would write from memory, because it is ordered by fact.

Validity, and the thing it prevents

Every card has validity dates, and the system makes **two overlapping cards on the same lane impossible** — not discouraged, impossible. If an import or an entry is rejected for overlapping an existing card, that is the protection working. Correct the dates on one of the two; do not work around it by creating the card under a slightly different lane.

This is the rule that stops two people quoting the same lane at two different prices in the same week.

Loading a card

Small changes by hand. A carrier contract arriving as a spreadsheet goes through **Network → Bulk import** — see `06-administrator.md`. It checks every line before writing anything, and if a single line fails, nothing is written.

Reference data — and why it is yours

Ports, places, commodities, exception codes, document types, charge types, milestone templates, working calendars.

This sits with operations rather than administration on purpose. A shipment routed through a depot nobody has recorded cannot be booked until somebody records it. If that waits for an administrator, what actually happens is that somebody types the depot into a notes field — and the system grows a free-text "other" that swallows the data it was built to structure.

So you can add a port on the morning a new lane opens. The corresponding responsibility: **add it properly, once.** Two entries for the same port is worse than none, because every report silently splits between them.

Milestone templates

The stages applied to a shipment when it is booked, per mode and direction.

Name them the way your operations people say them out loud, not the way a textbook does. If your team says "gate in", the milestone should say "gate in". People do not tick a checklist written in somebody else's vocabulary, and a milestone that is not ticked is a tracking page that lies to your customer.

Working calendars

Sunday to Thursday, plus your public holidays, per branch. Every SLA clock and every ageing rule counts against this. **Load next year's holidays before January**, or every deadline over the break will be wrong in the same direction.

Partners and agents

Agents, hauliers, carriers — with their compliance documents and expiry dates.

Keep the expiry dates real. An agent whose trade licence expired four months ago is a compliance problem that surfaces during an audit rather than during the job, and the register is only worth having if the dates in it are true.

The reversals

Cancelling a shipment

Available from draft, booked, in transit, on hold. It does not delete anything — the shipment stays, marked cancelled, with everything that happened to it intact.

Give the reason in the record, not in a WhatsApp message. In six months the question will be why, and the record is the only place that will still know.

Completing and closing

Complete means operationally finished — delivered, nothing outstanding. **Close** means financially finished, and it is the last step. Closing a job whose costs have not all landed is how a lane's margin ends up looking better than it was; the accrued free-time charges in particular arrive after delivery.

Check the job's costs before you close it, not after.

Releasing a hold

A held shipment returns to whichever stage it was in. Record why it was released in the exception that presumably caused it — a hold with no exception behind it is a decision nobody can reconstruct.

What to look at, and when

WHEN	WHAT	WHY
Every morning	Dashboard, top to bottom	Breached SLAs and the oldest exception
Every morning	Arriving this week	Documents and clearance, before it lands
Twice a week	Exceptions, oldest first	The top of that list is what nobody owns
Weekly	Demurrage accruing	Money leaving per day
Weekly	Rate cards — expiring within 30 days	Renew before a quotation needs it
Monthly	What each lane earns, thinnest first	The renegotiation list
Monthly	Win rate and average margin together	One without the other misleads
Quarterly	Lanes priced blind	Contracts to go and get
Before January	Working calendars	Next year's holidays

Things worth refusing

A coordinator asking you to fix a price on a quotation. Fix the rate card. Fixing the quotation fixes one job and hides a fault that will produce ten more.

A request for a free-text field. Every one of them is a report that cannot be run. If the data has categories, it belongs in reference data where it can be counted.

Closing a job to tidy the board. The board is meant to show what is outstanding. A tidy board with open costs behind it is a management report that is wrong.

Backfilled milestone dates. A week of dates entered on Thursday is a shipment that looks perfect and tells you nothing — and a customer who watched the tracking page say nothing for four days.